

The United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in December 2019 adopted the Resolution 74/212 that designates September 7 as the International Day of Clean Air for blue skies to raise awareness at all levels – individual, community, corporate, and government – that clean air is vital for health, productivity, the economy, and the environment. The Resolution underlines the importance and necessity to promote and facilitate actions to improve air quality. To this end, it stresses the need to strengthen international cooperation at the global, regional, and subregional levels in various areas related to improving air quality, including the collection and utilization of data, joint research and development, as well as the sharing of best practices. The International Day of Clean Air for blue skies was advocated by the Republic of Korea. The Resolution to hold the International Day of Clean Air for blue skies is a follow-up of the previous resolutions that were adopted by the United Nations Environment Assembly in its Resolution 3/8 of December 6, 2017, World Health Assembly in its Resolution 68.8 of May 26, 2015, and the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (ESCAP) in its Resolution 75/4 of May 31, 2019 that emphasize the significance of addressing the health impact of air pollution and strengthening international cooperation to tackle air pollution challenges. Against this backdrop, this Handbook was prepared as a reference for the International Day of Clean Air for blue skies. The official theme for the first International Day in 2020 is “Clean Air for All” with the goal of enhancing global solidarity and political momentum for actions against air pollution and climate change. The Handbook provides a guide to different stakeholders to join the collaborative efforts to address air pollution and contribute to the observance of this International Day.

Air pollutants can be broadly divided into two categories based on the source: primary air pollutants and secondary air pollutants. Primary air pollutants are air pollutants that are directly emitted from sources like factories, cars, etc. Examples include carbon monoxide (CO), carbon dioxide (CO₂), methane (CH₄), volatile organic compounds (VOCs), ammonia (NH₃), and sulfur dioxide (SO₂), and nitric oxide (NO). Secondary air pollutants are air pollutants that are generated in the atmosphere through a series of chemical reactions. Source: US EPA Examples include particulate matter (PM), ozone (O₃), nitric acid (HNO₃), sulfate (SO₄²⁻), sulfuric acid (H₂SO₄). Pollutants such as PM and nitrogen dioxide (NO₂) are both primary and secondary pollutants